

Chlorophyll A substance that absorbs the energy of sunlight, used by some living things to make sugar in the process of photosynthesis.

Chloroplast A microscopic organ within a plant cell or algal cell that contains chlorophyll, and makes sugar.

Cnidarian One of a group of marine animals that includes jellyfish and corals.

Coccolithophore A microscopic marine organism with a chalky skeleton.

Colony A group of animals or other organisms that live together.

Comet A space object made of ice and dust that orbits the Sun, trailing a stream of glowing gas.

Compound A substance that is made of the chemically bonded atoms of two or more elements. Sugar is a compound of carbon, hydrogen, and oxygen.

Continent A large landmass.

Continental crust A thick slab of relatively light rock that “floats” on the heavier rock of Earth’s mantle and forms a continent.

Continental drift The process by which continents are slowly dragged around the globe by the mobile plates of Earth’s crust.

Continental shelf The submerged fringe of a continent, forming the relatively shallow floor of a coastal sea.

Continental slope The edge of the continental shelf, which slopes down to the ocean floor.

Convection Circulating currents in gases or liquids such as air and water, and even hot, mobile rock, driven by differences in temperature.

Convergent boundary A boundary between two plates of Earth’s crust that are moving together, marked by earthquakes and volcanoes.

Copepod A tiny crustacean that lives in large swarms.

Coral A small sea animal that often has a hard base made of limestone and forms colonies. Over many years the limestone can build up into a coral reef.

Coral reef A rocky mass built up by corals with stony skeletons, which supports many other kinds of marine life.

Courtship Animal behavior, usually by males, designed to win a breeding partner.

Crustacean An animal with a hard external skeleton and paired, jointed legs, such as a crab or shrimp.

Cyclone A weather system of clouds, rain, and strong winds caused by air swirling into a region of warm, moist, rising air.

Detritivore An animal that eats the decomposed remains of other living things.

Diatom A single-celled oceanic organism that drifts as part of the phytoplankton. It has a skeleton of glassy silica.

Dinoflagellate A different type of single-celled oceanic organism that drifts as part of the phytoplankton.

Divergent boundary A boundary between two plates of Earth’s crust that are moving apart.

Dormant Inactive.

Dorsal fin The single fin on the back of a fish or whale.

Dune A heap of sand or similar material built up by the wind.

Echinoderm One of a group of spiny-skinned animals that includes starfish and sea urchins.

Echolocation Locating prey or other objects in water or air by transmitting sound pulses and detecting the echoes. The echoes create an image of the target.

Echo-sounding Finding the depth of water by transmitting a sound pulse and detecting the echo from the seabed. The time taken by the echo gives the depth.

Ecosystem An interacting community of living things in their natural environment.

Ekman transport The way moving water swerves increasingly to the right or left with depth, so that it moves in a different direction from the surface water.

Estuary A river mouth.

Evaporate To turn from a liquid to a gas or vapor.

Evolution The process by which living things change over time.

Excavate Dig up, often carefully and systematically, to reveal buried remains.

Extinct Having died out, or, in the case of a volcano, completely stopped erupting.

Fault A fracture in rock, where the rock on one side of the fracture has moved relative to the rock on the other side.

Fjord A deep valley gouged by a glacier, which is now flooded by the sea.

Fossil The remains or traces of any living thing that have survived the normal processes of decay, and have been preserved by being turned to stone.

Fracture zone An area of oceanic transform faults, which are sliding breaks in the ocean crust. These breaks extend away from spreading mid-ocean ridges.

Gastropod A type of mollusk that crawls on a long muscular foot, such as a snail.

Geyser A jet of hot water and steam that erupts from volcanically heated rocks.

Glacier A mass of ice made of compacted snow that flows slowly downhill.

Granite A hard rock that is one of the main rocks found in continental crust.

Gravity The force of attraction exerted by a large object such as planet Earth, which holds things on the planet surface and in orbit.

Gyre A large-scale circular pattern of ocean currents, rotating clockwise north of the equator, and counterclockwise south of the equator.